As the head of the SED, Honecker operated by a mixture of impulse and analysis. His popularity soared when he rolled-out pension increases, rent reductions and a generous credit system for young married couples. Amendments to the social security system extended wage payments in the event of illness, guaranteeing benefits for eighteen months. His overweening authority was also directed at increasing support for the upbringing of children of preschool age; Western pop music was allowed to be played again, long hair and jeans were no longer construed as a symbol of 'Western decadence' or an oppositional attitude. Moreover, previously banned books, for example Uncertain Friend by Stefan Heym, were allowed to appear and critical stage plays were performed and achieved great success.

Honecker was genuinely convinced there was a 'great deal of free play' for personal initiative by authors and artists. A writer in socialism, he reckoned, was a conscious, faithful and courageous comrade-in-arms of the working class, discovering and helping to shape the new reality.8 In one of his most sprightly speeches, he told a mass meeting of the Leipzig Region party organisation that:

no one is gripped by a mere cliché abstracted from life; what is moving and exciting in books and plays is what experiences can be shared and imagined in them, what gives clearer, more profound access to present, past and future. What is gripping is, as writers themselves say, the 'whole ensemble' of various characters, all striving forward. Given that, it should not be impossible to find the right mixture of conflicts; and in my opinion while the field between bad and good is certainly not a narrow one, the field between good and better is considerably broader and productive as well. In its cultural policy too, our party is taking Lenin's path, the path by which our writers and artists make a contribution valued by many people because of their closeness to the people and their party commitment, and